

we may judge by Strabo's evidence. Probably we should say till the Sassanian era, for the drastic religious changes which took place under those zealot kings are the first obvious opportunity for an innovation evidently most distasteful. The corollary suggests itself that the prose *Vendidad* may have been composed in that age: on this see p. 198.

The other Magian custom horrified the Greeks to much the same degree. If Xanthus Lydus can be relied upon, they knew of it as a peculiarity of the Magi as early as the fifth century B.C.¹ This is rather doubtfully endorsed by Herodotus when he remarks (iii. 31) that before Cambyses the Persians were not wont to marry their sisters. The form of the phrase rather suggests that Herodotus knew such a practice to be current at a later time. But he does not mention the Magi in connexion with this, and his silence suggests that he did not know of the practice as one prescribed by any body of teachers in the Persian Empire. The Xanthus fragment, decidedly our earliest witness for Greek knowledge of the matter, suggests some suspicion through the exaggeration of the statement: it may even mean that Xanthus also knew of Magian practice only by

¹ *Ap. Clem. Alex., Strom.*, iii. § 11 (p. 515): *μύγνυνται δὲ, φησὶν, οἱ μάγοι μητράσι καὶ θυγατράσι κτλ.* The extract, said to come from the *Μαγικά*, goes on to accuse the Magi of practical promiscuity. Müller (*Fragm. Hist. Græc.*, i. 43) declares the fragment inconsistent with that preserved by Nicolaus Damascenus. I do not quite see why. But there are weaker points about it than this. On the authenticity of the Xanthus fragments in general, see the note on Diogenes *Proæm.* below, p. 412. Naturally, the fragments need not be accepted or rejected *en bloc*: we may claim liberty to take them one at a time.

hearsay. Probably the Magi began their propaganda generations later, whatever their private practice was. In regard of this custom, modern Parsism, which has preserved the *dakhma*—an eminently sanitary, inexpensive, and even decorous provision in a country where vultures may be commanded, however repulsive on the first impression—has repudiated the *khvetuk-das* as heartily as any outsider could expect. The fullest argument against the imputation that incestuous marriages were belauded as a religious duty, whether in the Avesta or in the Pahlavi books, may be seen in a monograph by the distinguished editor of the Dînkart, Darab Dastur Peshotan Sanjana, *Next-of-kin Marriages in Old Irân* (London, 1888). It must be admitted, I fear, that the learned Dastur's argument against the evidence of classical authors is hardly capable of carrying the weight laid on it.¹ The hostile judgements upon the credibility of Herodotus, cited by him, have long ago vanished as fuller knowledge has shown us how remarkably good was the historian's information. And to cut out as a gloss the above-quoted statement of Strabo is a heroic expedient which only betrays the Parsi scholar's exceedingly pardonable bias. I cannot stop to discuss the matter here in its later developments, for Sassanian practice

¹ See the criticism of Dr Casartelli, in the *Babylonian and Oriental Record*, 1889—continued in 1890. The bulk of the paper is a discussion of the strange Vedic hymn (*Rv*, x. 10), in which Yamî woos her brother Yama, just as Yimak woos Yim in a Pahlavi *Rivâyet* translated by West (*SBE*, xviii. 418 f.). Dr Casartelli infers that this late Vedic hymn is an attack upon a custom known to prevail in some neighbouring race—one, as I should put it, which was closely akin to the Magi.

lies outside my period. Indeed, on my own definition the Vendidad ought likewise to be passed over, since it seems highly probable that this part of it is Sassanian. But an actual Avestan passage can hardly be overlooked. Bartholomae (*AirWb*, 1860—where see literature) is very positive that the institution is known to the Avesta. Under $\chi^v a \acute{e} t v a d a \theta a$ he gives the etymology $\chi^v a \acute{e} t u$, “kin,” and $v a d a \theta a$, “marriage,” despite Justi’s objection. So far I do not see how to question his case, but I would note that the word does not occur in any Avestan text that has a claim to come from the earlier age: I should myself be prepared to put the passages quite late. But when Prof. Bartholomae proceeds (*AirWb*, 1822) to make Queen Hutaosa the sister as well as wife of Vishtaspa, and to find evidence not only in the Pahlavi literature but in *Yt* 15³⁶, I feel the greatest doubt of the inference. In this Yasht passage—which is metrical—Hutaosa “of the many brothers, of the Naotara house,” prays to Vayu that she may be “dear and loved and well received in the house of King Vishtaspa.” Should we not infer that she was about to enter that house for the first time, as a bride? It is stated that both Vishtaspa and his Queen belonged to the Naotara family.¹ That would not make them brother and sister; and Darmesteter further remarks that the Bundahish (31²⁸) excluded

¹ Vishtaspa is called by implication a member of the *Naotairye* in *Yt* 5⁹⁸, a verse passage. The clan pray to Anahita for swift horses, and receive the gift—“Vishtaspa became possessed of the swiftest horses in those lands”—by matrimonial alliance with this house, it might be suggested! Vishtaspa’s name was enough to bring him in where it was a matter of possessing horses (*aspa*).

Vishtaspa from this family.¹ “Perhaps he was considered a Naotaride on account of his wife” (*SBE*, xxiii. 77 n). Is it not more reasonable to take the Yasht passage in its obvious sense, and charge the Pahlavi glossators with the interpretation which would make the royal patron of Zarathushtra the first example of their much-lauded virtue? For that the practice is lauded in this literature is really beyond question. The paramount authority of E. W. West has fairly settled it,² and his demonstration gives all the more weight to his opinion that it is not proven for the Avesta. I refer to West’s dissertation specially for his proof that the writers were urging on the people a practice which they would not receive. This is exactly the impression that the classical evidence makes. A rule peculiar to an alien tribe, strongly marked with traces of barbarous origin surviving into later days under the influence of religion, remained peculiar to them to the last. That instances occurred in the royal family is another matter. Herodotus makes no suggestion that there were Magi at the court of Cambyses, and his “judges” expressly declared that they knew no law permitting marriage of brother and sister. The king’s own character is abundantly bad enough—or mad enough—to account for his act. Artaxerxes I. might be a similar case, though by this time the Magi could have intervened: there is no proof that they did. Personal viciousness, and an increasing jealousy of introducing foreign elements into the royal house, will be sufficient

¹ *Bund* 31²⁹ mentions Vishtaspa, but I see no reference to the Naotara family in the context as West gives it (*SBE*, v. 137).

² *SBE*, xviii. 389–430: *cf.* preface, p. xxviii f.